

As computers become more and more integrated into our lives, we end up leaving a lot of sensitive information on our PCs—from passwords, e-mail IDs (even official e-mail IDs) and bank accounts to personal diaries and notes, business plans (or worse still, tender bids), confidential documents, a log of surfing habits (which can be viewed out of context), a backup of phone SMSes, and much more.

Then there is another risk, especially when you are online—viruses and spyware. Though viruses and spyware are talked about in the same breath, there is one fundamental difference: a virus is written to cause damage to your operating system, programs or files, usually with no direct benefit to the virus creator. Spyware, on the other hand, is written for gain. This could be by tracking the surfing habits of a user on an infected computer and sending this information to someone who would send the user advertisements supposedly targeted at him based on his surfing habits.

Very strictly speaking, spyware is not intended to cause damage, at least in the traditional sense, but more often than not, they end up doing so on your PC, which is rendered difficult to repair. You can find more details on viruses and spyware in the third and fourth chapter of this book.

When we speak of computer security, what we mean is the ways in which you can prevent people from accessing data on your computer, keep your computer safe from viruses and spyware, and protect yourself from hacking and phishing.

Let us take a brief look at the ways in which your security could be compromised. You will find more details on each of these in the respective chapters.